

THIS ISSUE TRAINS · READING WHAT SHORTAGES ARE TELLING YOU

Money and markets

Silver ran to all time highs above USD 60 per ounce in December 2025, and the reason was refreshingly physical: there was not enough actual deliverable metal for everyone who wanted it.

When buyers need the real thing now and sellers are scarce, price stops reflecting long term value and starts reflecting short term urgency, climbing until someone is persuaded to part with theirs. Paper promises can be printed on demand. Bars of metal cannot.

The SCD takeaway: when the physical thing runs out, price stops being an opinion and becomes a ration card.

Sources: CNBC, December 10, 2025.

Engineering corner

Pulling lithium straight from salty water. Direct lithium extraction, named a top emerging technology of 2026, uses selective materials to pull lithium ions directly out of natural brines instead of evaporating giant ponds for months. Lithium sits in every phone and EV battery, and demand keeps outrunning the old ways of producing it.

The SCD takeaway: higher prices ration a shortage; better engineering ends it. Both are answers to the same signal.

Source: World Economic Forum, Top 10 Emerging Technologies of 2026.

Your move

A shortage does not just raise a price. The price is a signal, and the signal recruits people: traders who ration what exists, and engineers who attack the supply problem itself. The spike is the advertisement that starts the next story.

This week, on your own: find one price around you that jumped recently and work out whether the cause was more buyers or fewer sellers. The two problems have completely different fixes.